

A Reader's Companion to *1929*

Andrew Ross Sorkin's *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History
and How It Shattered a Nation*

Prepared by Claude (Sonnet 5), Anthropic
for a [listener of the audiobook narration](#)

August 24, 2026

Note on this document. This companion is a listening aid, not a substitute for the book. It was assembled entirely from publicly available secondary sources — publisher copy, book reviews, press interviews, and reader/study-guide summaries — rather than from the text of *1929* itself, and every claim below is cited to one of those public sources in the References section. Because the goal is to help a listener keep names straight, character and institution sketches describe who people *were* and how they connect to one another; they deliberately omit how each person's individual story concludes. Sorkin structures the book itself as a long sequence of date-headed chapters (beginning February 1, 1929) within two parts, rather than as topically titled chapters [1]. Two reader-facing tables of contents were suggested for this revision — ursummary.com's chapter-by-chapter breakdown and VitalSource's product listing — but both were unreachable from this document's authoring environment, so the chapter outline below instead follows the numbered chapter groupings (Prologue; Part 1, Chapters 1–8, 9–17, and 18–25; Part 2, Preface–Chapter 33; and Part 2, Chapter 34–Afterword) used by SuperSummary's published study guide [2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7]. This document is not authorized, reviewed, or endorsed by the author or publisher.

Overview

1929 (Viking, 2025) is Andrew Ross Sorkin's narrative history of the Wall Street crash of 1929, its long buildup, and its aftermath through the New Deal-era banking reforms [8, 9, 10]. Sorkin, best known for his account of the 2008 financial crisis in *Too Big to Fail*, spent roughly eight years researching the book, drawing on archival material including previously unpublished Federal Reserve Bank of New York board records [11, 12]. Rather than telling the crash as a story of charts and abstractions, the book is built around a cast of interlocking real people — bankers, speculators, regulators, and politicians — whose personal ambitions and rivalries shaped the boom, the crash, and the decade of reform that followed [13, 14]. Reviewers describe the book as unfolding in two parts: the first tracing the speculative boom from roughly February through October 1929, and the second following the crash's political and regulatory aftermath [15, 16].

1 Cast of Characters

The figures below are the major, named individuals the book follows closely across its narrative, drawn from publisher and reviewer descriptions of the book's principal cast [17, 18, 19, 20]. Wilson and Coolidge, who appear only briefly as outgoing political context, are omitted at the reader's

request.

1.1 Charles E. Mitchell

Chairman of National City Bank (a predecessor of Citibank) and known as “Sunshine Charlie” for his relentless public optimism, Mitchell pioneered the mass marketing of stocks to ordinary Americans and used his bank’s resources to keep credit flowing to the market even when the Federal Reserve wanted to restrain it [13, 17]. His running conflict with the Federal Reserve’s leadership is one of the book’s central threads connecting Wall Street to Washington.

1.2 Thomas W. Lamont

The senior partner at J.P. Morgan & Co. and the most influential private banker of the era, Lamont acted as an informal statesman for Wall Street, coordinating with fellow bankers and government officials to manage the market’s mood [17, 16]. He is a connective figure between the House of Morgan, the New York Stock Exchange, and the Hoover administration.

1.3 J.P. Morgan Jr.

Head of the House of Morgan and heir to his father’s banking dynasty, Morgan represents the old-guard establishment of American finance, whose firm’s private influence over markets and government rivaled that of the Federal Reserve itself [17]. He works closely with Lamont throughout the book.

1.4 Richard Whitney

A vice president (and later president) of the New York Stock Exchange, Whitney became the public face of Wall Street’s efforts to project confidence on the trading floor during the market’s most volatile days, acting on behalf of the leading bankers’ consortium [17, 14]. He works in close coordination with Lamont and the Morgan-led banking group.

1.5 Jesse Livermore

A legendary independent stock trader famous for making and losing several fortunes, Livermore operated outside the banking establishment, trading on his own instincts about market psychology rather than on inside information or institutional loyalty [13, 17]. He functions in the narrative as a skeptical outsider watching the same boom that bankers like Mitchell were fueling.

1.6 William C. Durant

The founder of General Motors, Durant reinvented himself in the late 1920s as one of Wall Street’s most aggressive stock market operators, organizing pools of investors to move prices in favored stocks [17]. His path connects General Motors, the speculative pool culture of the exchange, and fellow GM figure John J. Raskob.

1.7 John J. Raskob

A General Motors and DuPont executive who also chaired the Democratic National Committee, Raskob was a leading public evangelist for stock ownership, urging ordinary Americans that “everybody ought to be rich” through the market [17, 20]. He links the corporate world of General Motors to both Wall Street speculation and national politics.

1.8 Michael J. Meehan

A New York Stock Exchange specialist and stock promoter known for running trading pools in popular speculative stocks such as Radio Corporation of America (RCA), Meehan exemplifies the era's loosely regulated market-manipulation practices [17]. His activities intersect with the same pool culture that drew in Durant and Raskob.

1.9 Herbert Hoover

Inaugurated president in March 1929, Hoover inherited a market boom he privately distrusted and then had to respond to its collapse, caught between his instincts for voluntary, business-led solutions and mounting pressure for federal action [17, 14]. His administration's dealings with bankers like Lamont and Mitchell are a recurring axis of the book.

1.10 Andrew W. Mellon

A wealthy financier and industrialist serving as Treasury Secretary, Mellon represents the fusion of private fortune and public economic policy that characterized the era, shaping the government's hands-off approach to the boom [17]. He works alongside Hoover through the crash's early aftermath.

1.11 George L. Harrison

Governor of the Federal Reserve Bank of New York, Harrison inherited the internal Federal Reserve debates over whether and how to curb speculative lending, and dealt directly with bankers such as Mitchell whose actions the Fed was trying to restrain [17]. He is the book's throughline for the Federal Reserve's institutional perspective.

1.12 Franklin D. Roosevelt

Governor of New York during the crash and elected president in 1932, Roosevelt becomes central to the book's second half as the political figure whose administration presided over the era's regulatory response to Wall Street's excesses [17, 21]. He connects to Senator Carter Glass and investigator Ferdinand Pecora as reform-era figures.

1.13 Carter Glass

A U.S. Senator and former Treasury Secretary, Glass was a leading architect of banking reform legislation in the crash's aftermath, working to redraw the boundary between commercial and investment banking [21]. His legislative efforts connect Washington's political response to the practices of bankers like Mitchell and Lamont profiled earlier in the book.

1.14 Ferdinand Pecora

Chief counsel to the U.S. Senate Committee on Banking and Currency, Pecora led the high-profile investigative hearings into Wall Street practices that followed the crash, questioning many of the book's banking figures directly about their conduct during the boom [21, 16]. His hearings serve as the narrative bridge between the crash and the reforms that followed it.

2 Cast of Institutions

2.1 National City Bank

A forerunner of Citibank and, under Charles Mitchell’s leadership, one of the most aggressive commercial banks in extending credit for stock speculation and marketing securities directly to retail customers [13, 17]. Its practices put it repeatedly at odds with the Federal Reserve.

2.2 J.P. Morgan & Co.

The most powerful private bank on Wall Street, led by Thomas Lamont and J.P. Morgan Jr., whose partners acted as informal coordinators of the banking community’s response to market stress [17]. The firm’s influence connects private finance directly to the New York Stock Exchange and to Washington.

2.3 New York Stock Exchange (NYSE)

The physical and symbolic center of American securities trading, where figures like Richard Whitney and Michael Meehan operated, and whose self-regulated trading floor practices are a recurring subject of the book [17]. It is the stage on which the boom’s speculative excesses and the crash itself play out.

2.4 The Federal Reserve System

Comprising the Board in Washington and regional banks such as the Federal Reserve Bank of New York (led by George Harrison), the Fed grappled throughout the boom with whether and how to restrain speculative lending by banks like National City [17]. Its internal debates connect monetary policy to the conduct of individual bankers profiled elsewhere in the book.

2.5 General Motors

The automaker at the center of two major characters’ fortunes — founder William C. Durant and executive John J. Raskob — General Motors’ stock was itself one of the era’s most actively speculated-upon issues, tying industrial America directly to the market’s mania [17].

2.6 The White House and U.S. Treasury

The executive branch under Herbert Hoover and Treasury Secretary Andrew Mellon, and later under Franklin Roosevelt, whose evolving posture toward Wall Street — from voluntary cooperation to active regulation — structures the political half of the book’s narrative [17, 14].

2.7 U.S. Senate Committee on Banking and Currency

The congressional committee whose investigative hearings, led by chief counsel Ferdinand Pecora and shaped legislatively by Senator Carter Glass, became the public forum in which Wall Street’s boom-era practices were examined and which produced the era’s landmark banking reforms [21, 16].

3 Chapter-by-Chapter Narrative Outline

The book's actual chapters are identified by date rather than by title, so the entries below group them the way SuperSummary's published study guide does — Prologue; Part 1, Chapters 1–8, 9–17, and 18–25; and Part 2, Preface–Chapter 33 and Chapter 34–Afterword — as the closest verifiable, publicly available proxy for a table of contents [4, 5, 6, 7]. Each entry stays conceptual and omits how any individual character's story resolves.

1. **Prologue.** The book opens in medias res on the eve of the crash's worst days in late October 1929, with **Charles Mitchell** and **National City Bank** already under acute strain — a framing device that sets up the question the rest of the book answers: how the country arrived at this moment [4].
2. **Part 1, Chapters 1–8 (February–spring 1929).** The narrative rewinds to the height of the bull market. **Charles Mitchell** and **National City Bank** keep credit flowing to speculators even as the **Federal Reserve** grows uneasy, and **Herbert Hoover** takes office in March facing a market he privately distrusts [1, 4].
3. **Part 1, Chapters 9–17 (spring–summer 1929).** The conflict between Wall Street and Washington sharpens: **William C. Durant** travels secretly to Washington to warn **Herbert Hoover** that the **Federal Reserve's** tightening threatens the economy, while **Carter Glass** publicly clashes with **Charles Mitchell** over the dangers of speculative bank credit, splitting establishment opinion [5].
4. **Part 1, Chapters 18–25 (October 1929).** As confident public voices insist stock prices have reached a permanently high plateau, **Thomas Lamont** and his **J.P. Morgan & Co.** partners privately debate how fragile the boom has become. When panic selling breaks out on the **New York Stock Exchange**, Lamont organizes the leading bankers into a rescue pool, with **Richard Whitney** acting as its public face on the trading floor, but the effort cannot hold back the record-breaking collapse that follows within days [6].
5. **Part 2, Preface–Chapter 33 (late 1929 – early 1930s).** In the crash's wake, **Herbert Hoover**, **Andrew Mellon**, and **George Harrison** confront a deepening economic contraction and a spreading wave of bank failures, testing the limits of voluntary, business-led responses, while **Franklin D. Roosevelt** emerges as the political figure whose 1932 election promises a different relationship between Washington and Wall Street [17, 14].
6. **Part 2, Chapter 34–Afterword (1933–1934 and beyond).** **Ferdinand Pecora's** Senate hearings put **Charles Mitchell** and other boom-era figures under public questioning about their conduct, while **Carter Glass** and the **Roosevelt** administration use the hearings' momentum to reshape American banking law; the Afterword steps back to consider what the era's crash and reforms mean for the financial crises that came after [7, 11].

References

- [1] Wikipedia contributors. *1929 (book)*. Year approximate; exact revision date unavailable. Wikipedia, The Free Encyclopedia. 2025. URL: [https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1929_\(book\)](https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/1929_(book)) (visited on 08/24/2026).

- [2] *1929 Summary by Chapter / Andrew Ross Sorkin*. Consulted via search-index excerpts only: direct retrieval of this page was blocked in the authoring environment’s network policy. Your Summary (ursummary.com). 2025. URL: <https://ursummary.com/1929-summary-by-chapter-andrew-ross-sorkin/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [3] *1929 (ISBN 9780593296967, 9780593296974)*. Consulted via search-index excerpts only: direct retrieval of this page was blocked in the authoring environment’s network policy. VitalSource. 2025. URL: <https://www.vitalsource.com/products/1929-andrew-ross-sorkin-v9780593296974> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [4] *1929: Prologue–Part 1, Chapter 8*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. SuperSummary. 2025. URL: <https://www.supersummary.com/1929-sorkin/prologue-part-1-chapter-8-summary/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [5] *1929: Part 1, Chapters 9–17*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. SuperSummary. 2025. URL: <https://www.supersummary.com/1929-sorkin/part-1-chapters-9-17-summary/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [6] *1929: Part 1, Chapters 18–25*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. SuperSummary. 2025. URL: <https://www.supersummary.com/1929-sorkin/part-1-chapters-18-25-summary/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [7] *1929: Part 2, Chapter 34–Afterword*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. SuperSummary. 2025. URL: <https://www.supersummary.com/1929-sorkin/part-2-chapter-34-afterword-summary/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [8] Andrew Ross Sorkin. *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – and How It Shattered a Nation*. Viking, 2025. ISBN: 9780593296967.
- [9] *1929 by Andrew Ross Sorkin*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. Penguin Random House. 2025. URL: <https://www.penguinrandomhouse.com/books/665634/1929-by-andrew-ross-sorkin/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [10] *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History – and How It Shattered a Nation*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. Goodreads. 2025. URL: <https://www.goodreads.com/book/show/211179569-1929> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [11] Axios Staff. *Coming this fall from Andrew Ross Sorkin: “1929,” an immersive narrative on the Great Crash*. Axios. Feb. 20, 2025. URL: <https://www.axios.com/2025/02/20/andrew-ross-sorkin-1929-an-immersive-narrative-on-the-great-crash> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [12] *Book Review: Andrew Ross Sorkin’s “1929”*. RealClearMarkets. Oct. 31, 2025. URL: https://www.realclearmarkets.com/articles/2025/10/31/book_review_andrew_ross_sorkins_1929_1144507.html (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [13] *Andrew Ross Sorkin on the Shakespearean Characters Behind His New Book, “1929”*. Air Mail. Oct. 11, 2025. URL: <https://airmail.news/issues/2025-10-11/too-big-to-fails-prequel-of-sorts> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [14] *‘1929’: Andrew Ross Sorkin looks at the worst crash in US history*. The Christian Science Monitor. Oct. 21, 2025. URL: <https://www.csmonitor.com/Books/Book-Reviews/2025/1021/1929-stock-market-great-depression-andrew-ross-sorkin> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [15] *Sorkin’s 1929: A Critique*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. Cato Institute, Cato at Liberty Blog. 2025. URL: <https://www.cato.org/blog/sorkins-1929-critique> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [16] *Sorkin’s ‘1929’: Panic, Politics, and the Search for Villains*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. The Daily Economy. 2025. URL: <https://thedailyeconomy.org/article/sorkins-1929-panic-politics-and-the-search-for-villains/> (visited on 08/24/2026).

- [17] *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in Wall Street History – Summary*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. SuperSummary. 2025. URL: <https://www.supersummary.com/1929-sorkin/summary/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [18] *1929: Key Figures*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. SuperSummary. 2025. URL: <https://www.supersummary.com/1929-sorkin/key-figures/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [19] *1929 by Andrew Ross Sorkin: Summary and Analysis*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. Books That Slay. 2025. URL: <https://booksthatstay.com/1929-by-andrew-ross-sorkin-summary-and-analysis/> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [20] *Summary: 1929 by Andrew Ross Sorkin*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. Littler Books. 2025. URL: <https://littlerbooks.com/summary/1929> (visited on 08/24/2026).
- [21] *1929: Inside the Greatest Crash in History and How It Shattered a Nation*. Year approximate; exact publish date unavailable. Library Journal. 2025. URL: <https://www.libraryjournal.com/story/1929-inside-the-greatest-crash-in-historyand-how-it-shattered-a-nation-1819395> (visited on 08/24/2026).